

# **The Paper I Couldn't Fill**

Lojine Goumaa

ENG-125

“Describe yourself without adjectives. Tell me, who are you?” she asked.

She sat on the brown leather chair across from me with cracks revealing the fabric underneath the leather, a worn-down journal in her lap, and a pen in her left hand. I’ve always liked that she was left-handed; it reminded me that someone that had a similar trait to me is content and accomplished her goals, meaning that I had a chance of doing the same.

She knew who I was; she had been my therapist for 2 years. I let silence fill the air for many minutes, slouched over, observing my hands on my lap. I wasn’t entirely sure what she meant—if not with adjectives, then how else am I meant to describe myself? My hobbies? Accomplishments? My bad habits? Perhaps even good ones, if I had any.

“I don’t know.” I said, breaking the silence that I wish could somehow speak for me.

She sighed, looking down at her empty journal, probably wondering if I’d ever make progress. Sure, self-esteem issues and anxiety are something almost everyone suffers from, my case was not her first nor her last. the one thing that differentiated me from the others was that I refused to get better. It’s as if my mind was aware of my circumstances and was comfortable enough where it was at. Stubborn is what I would’ve told her if I could’ve used adjectives.

“I have an assignment for you.” She leaned over and handed me a blank piece of paper.

“I want you to write down everything you wish to do with your life, and the one thing that is stopping you.”

Simple answer, right? Definitely something I could easily answer with no trouble, right? Except, it wasn't, and I didn't care enough to think of one. I wasn't entirely sure the purpose of this and the many other useless assignments that were supposed to assist me in progressing. There was no use, I wasn't getting better, nor was I sure if I truly wanted to.

“Okay” I said as enthusiastically one hopeless person could sound. I looked up at her face filled with what I translated as despair, empathy, pity, or perhaps a mix of everything combined.

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One week later, I had reached my lowest, not knowing I could even get lower, but I managed to achieve it. I had lost a sense of purpose and identity became a faint memory that I used to know the meaning of. An indent formed on my bed as my body rested there like a lifeless corpse for what felt like days when only a few hours passed.

There were times in which I thought about her question that she asked alongside the blank paper she gave me, wondering if I'd ever formulate the right answer because surely, there is one, right? There's a reason as to why I was like this. My mind ran empty; there was nothing I could think of to put on that paper. I did have dreams and aspirations, and they were easy to think of. The

worry wasn't whether I'd lost a sense of direction or purpose of my life, it was if I was worthy enough to achieve what I could so easily envision for others.

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A day later, I found myself in the same chair with the same familiar face across from me. "Did you complete your assignment?" She inquired; her eyebrows raised as she took a glimpse of the empty paper sitting on my lap. Her lips pursed.

"I couldn't think of anything," I said candidly, shifting in my seat.

She stared blankly for a moment before scribbling in her journal. I immediately knew I made a mistake. I could tell she was already at the edge of discharging me and demanding I find another therapist to work with, perhaps tell me that I was a lost cause and there was nothing anyone could do if I was unwilling to cooperate. I clung to the faintest spark of faith that it was possible for something to be done without having to really *do* anything. Laziness would've been another adjective.

Our gazes met again, and a heavy sigh left her. "I'll give you another two weeks to do it. We won't move on until something is written on that paper."

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Initially, her strategy of demanding it be completed didn't work. The paper laid dormant on my desk, still blank and soon an obstacle as I moved it to my floor to make room for the piles of dishes forming. The blank page watched as my anxiety worsened over the duration of those two weeks as I let my academics determine every ounce of self-worth I had left. The anxiety sparked

at random times unpredictably; It felt as though a gun was held to my chest, with the trigger being pulled every so often. I could never take a test without an anxiety attack emerging, let alone achieve my goals. Another life path could've suited me well. I missed who I was before the anxiety, before I cared about the unknown looming future, about becoming the best version of myself, and if I'd ever reach it or be her.

Eventually, the dishes hoarded the desk of use, and the paper on the unvacuumed floor had become wrinkled and aged as I had forgotten of its existence. It looked used, yet not a single word was written on it. I knew what to write, but writing it down meant I had to acknowledge it, and I wasn't sure if I'd ever be ready for it.

I blame anxiety as if I was the victim, when I was the one that chose to be anxious; it was a drug I was addicted to. This wasn't just self-sabotage; I was slowly throwing my life down the drain. I was the one who held that gun to my chest, and I was the one firing it. With my thoughts telling me to do otherwise, my left hand grabbed the black pen.

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A smile crept on her face as she closed her journal shut, placing it beside her with the pen laying above it. Her smile felt like the gun had finally run out of ammo.

She tilted her head slightly. "May I see?" she asked, stretching her arm out to reach for the paper. she must have seen the marks of pen on it before I informed her that I finally had something written. The chair felt extra soft, and my chest relaxed as it began healing from the shot wounds. I saw her skimming through my first response, and I knew when her eyes had finally reached the

bottom of the page where my second response remained. Her smile left as fast as it came, and her posture straightened.

I knew what she had read.

*one thing that is stopping me:*

*myself.*

I had to face that this was not something that she could fix for me as I had wanted her to and the way her eyes glimmered from the tears forming, she knew that too.

hopeful could've been a fitting adjective.